

FORESHADOWING

Hinting at events before they happen



1 What is it?

Foreshadowing

Foreshadowing gives the reader a **subtle hint or clue** about something that will happen later in the text — often only obvious in hindsight, on a second read.

small hint now → bigger event later

2 See it in action

An ominous detail

A character mentions a storm forecast early on — the storm later becomes central to the plot.

A warning ignored

"Be careful on that road," someone warns, moments before the real danger arrives.

Symbolic imagery

A wilting flower early in a story can foreshadow a character's decline.

In film

A gun shown on a wall in an early scene hints it will be used later (Chekhov's Gun).



Good spot!

Foreshadowing is often **easy to miss on a first read** — if you're rereading a text for an exam, actively hunt for small details that only make sense once you know the ending.

FUN FACT

"Chekhov's Gun" is a famous writing principle: if a gun appears on the wall in Act One, it must be fired by Act Three — every early detail should earn its place by paying off later.

3 Why writers use it

Foreshadowing helps writers: build tension and anticipation, reward attentive readers who catch the clue, and make a later event feel planned and inevitable rather than random.

Good foreshadowing is subtle enough that first-time readers might miss it, but feels obvious and satisfying once the event it hinted at actually happens.

4 Where you'll spot it

Thriller & horror

A small unsettling detail early on that pays off as a major twist later.

Film soundtracks

A brief, ominous musical cue can foreshadow danger before anything visible happens.



Watch out!

Don't confuse foreshadowing with a flashback — foreshadowing points FORWARD to something not yet happened; a flashback points BACKWARD to something already happened.



Keep going!

Ask what **mood or expectation** the foreshadowing creates, even before the reader consciously understands what it's pointing towards.

5 Quick recap

A subtle hint about the future

Builds tension and anticipation

Often clearer on a second read



Mfalme says...

Try planting one small, easy-to-miss detail early in a short story that quietly sets up your ending — see if a friend notices it on a first read.